Alice felt a mixture of curiosity and trepidation. “Hit me,” she said, sniffing from the glass of Bordeaux she had poured. It was opening up nicely.

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“Okay,” he began. His own drink was a gin martini, not too dry, three olives. “Let’s start with the obvious. Occam’s razor. We’re all taught in kindergarten that we should prefer simple explanations over unnecessarily complicated ones. Now, if I follow your work at all—maybe I don’t—it seems to me that you’re comfortable postulating an infinite number of unseen worlds. Doesn’t that seem a bit extravagant? Directly the opposite of the simplest possible explanation?”

Alice nodded. “Well, it depends on how we define ‘simple,’ of course. My philosophy colleagues sometimes cast this as a worry about ‘ontological commitment’—roughly, the amount of stuff we need to imagine is contained in all of reality, just to describe our observed portion of it.”

“So wouldn’t Occam’s razor suggest that having too many ontological commitments is an unattractive feature in a fundamental theory?”

“Sure, but you have to be a little careful about what that commitment actually is. Many-Worlds doesn’t *assume* a large number of worlds. What it assumes is a wave function evolving according to the Schrödinger equation. The worlds are there automatically.”

Her father objected. “What do you mean by that? It’s literally called the Many-Worlds theory. Of course it assumes a large number of worlds.”

“Not really,” replied Alice, becoming more animated as she warmed to the subject. “The ingredients used in Many-Worlds are ingredients that are used by *every other version of quantum mechanics*. To get rid of the other worlds, alternatives need to posit additional assumptions: either new dynamics in addition to the Schrödinger equation, or new variables in addition to the wave function, or an entirely separate view of reality. Ontologically speaking, Many-Worlds is as lean and mean as you can possibly get.”

“You’re kidding.”